7.3 Climate Change and Sustainability

The Earth's climate has changed throughout history. In the last 650,000 years there have been several cycles of glacial and warm periods each lasting thousands or millions of years. Most of these climate changes are attributed to very small variations in earth's orbit that changes the amount of solar energy our planet receives. It is understood that at present the Earth's climate is getting warmer which is referred to as 'Global Warming'. Earth's temperature has gone up about one degree Fahrenheit in the last 100 years. This is a very small change but small changes in earth's temperature can have big effects. Some effects are already happening such as melting of glaciers, rise in the level of oceans, prolonged droughts, excessive rain and floods, etc.

Reasons for Climate change

Burning fossil fuels emits gases into the atmosphere. Burning fossil fuel to provide energy, coupled with the effects of major transportation and deforestation causes a rapid increase in global temperatures. This can change the climate of a place.

Effects of climate change – Scientists had predicted in the past that the result from global climate change are now occurring, loss of sea ice, accelerated sea level rise and longer, more intense heat waves.

1. **Temperatures will continue to rise** - Experts agree that greenhouse gases which trap heat and prevent it from leaving the earth's atmosphere are mostly responsible for the temperature spike.
2. **Frost- free season (and growing season) will lengthen** - it could actually have detrimental effects on the crops we grow. Warmer weather helps pests survive longer which can destroy crops. Rising temperatures are also expected to contribute to a shift in areas which are agriculturally most productive and the crops that grow there.
3. **Changes in precipitation patterns** - The contrast between wet and dry areas will increase globally. In other words, the wet areas will get wetter and the dry areas will get drier.
4. **More droughts and heat waves** - With rising temperatures and shifting rainfall patterns, heat waves and droughts are increasing in frequency and intensity.
5. **Sea level rise** - Scientists have determined that global sea level has been steadily rising since 1900 at a rate of at least 0.1 to 0.25 centimeter per year. Sea level can rise by two different mechanisms with respect to climate change.
6. **Arctic likely to become ice-free** - The Arctic Ocean is expected to become essentially ice free in summer before mid-century.



UNFCCC Process for Climate Change Adaptation, On17, May 2017: Policy makers, implementers, supporters and investors from all over the world met during the UNFCCC Bonn Climate Change Conference at the Technical Expert Meeting (TEM) on Adaptation to discuss 'Integrating climate change adaptation with the Sustainable Development Goals and the Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction.

Response to Climate Change

There are two main responses to climate change.

1. Mitigation - which addresses the root causes of climate change, by reducing greenhouse gas emissions.

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